F&B

Lifting *Our* Spirits

Whisky clubs in India are fostering a sense of community and awareness among both novices and connoisseurs



India, history and statistics both suggest, has loved whisky ever since the British introduced us to it. Nothing—not our thriving wine industry nor the current craft gin revolution—has dented its popularity. Be it Scotch, blended whiskies, bourbons or Japanese malts, Indians are today drinking more whisky than ever. Over the past few years, Indian single malts have also carved a sizeable niche for themselves, with brands like Amrut, Paul John, Rampur et al holding their own against imported whiskies. "Indians are drinking better and there's a clear trend towards single malts. People are also far more aware and educated about brands than before," says sommelier Nikhil Agarwal, CEO of All Things Nice (allthingsnice.in), a luxury wine and spirits consulting agency that curates experiential events such as whisky-cigar pairings, blind tastings, jazz and whisky evenings.

All Things Nice is by no means the only Indian outfit shouldering that sometimes heavy mantle of awareness. The Dram Club (thedramclub.in), too, organises masterclasses and whisky pairings. The whisky club recently hosted a private tasting of whiskies from the Glendronach distillery for the first time in India. Co-founder Swati Sharma says, "During our trips abroad, we found many whisky groups that were friendly and welcoming, but the ones in Mumbai were rather close and restrictive. Our idea was to make whisky fun, inclusive and democratic, appreciating the liquid for what it truly is and looking beyond the label on the bottle." In an effort to help consumers select the best whisky, Dram Club has also launched an app. "While most whiskies featured on the app have been reviewed by us, app users have also begun adding their reviews, making it an independent space in which you can discover whiskies", says co-founder Vinayak Singh.

THE EVENTS AND TASTINGS ORGANISED BY INDIA'S WHISKY CLUBS ARE BRINGING IN A YOUNGER CLIENTELE



In Bengaluru, the decade-old Single Malt Amateur Club (smacindia.com) has been a platform for amateurs, professionals,

SETTING THE BAR HIGH ▸ *Best whisky bars in India*



BASTIAN, *Mumbai*

The spacious Bastian in Worli has a huge collection of whiskies, with something for every budget. Their expert mixologist also comes up with fantastic whisky cocktails like Appleberry Rocks (bourbon, fresh apples, and raspberry puree).

THE COLLECTION, *Bengaluru*



If you are in Bengaluru, wanting to sample a curated assortment of whiskies from around the world, head to The Collection at Four Seasons Hotel. Here you will also find sumptuous signature cocktails.